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ALASKA
GROUP CRUISE!

NCL BLISS
July 11 - 18, 2026

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- JUNEAU
- ICY STRAIT POINT
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Solo Cruisers Alaska Group Cruise · NCL Bliss · July 11–18, 2026 ·
Sitka, Juneau, Icy Strait Point, Ketchikan, Victoria BC · Solo Studio
Cabin from \$1269, no single supplement · Hosted by Kristie McClung
Escoe

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**

Hosted by Kristie McClung Escoe

Welcome

Made for the solo cruiser who has already booked this specific hosted sailing and wants one trusted read on the week — the ship, the five ports, and the group's rhythm, in one place.

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier: a 7-night Alaska round-trip from Seattle on **Norwegian Bliss**, July 11 – 18, 2026, calling at **Sitka, Juneau, Icy Strait Point, Ketchikan, and Victoria BC**. It's a **hosted solo cruisers group cruise** organized by **Kristie McClung Escoe**.

It pulls together the ship-specific tips, port-specific advice, packing notes calibrated for an Alaska summer, the group's pre-cruise and onboard rhythm Kristie has set, and the budget math you'd otherwise assemble from a dozen browser tabs.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads.

A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

I haven't sailed this itinerary on this ship. Two kinds of experience stand behind the pack anyway: **Kristie has been to Alaska three times** — her host notes and the schedule she's set are hers, and they're quoted as hers. Everything else — the docking arrangements, shuttle systems, excursion operators and their prices, port layouts, transit timetables — comes from primary-source research: the port terminals' own websites, the operators' own price pages, the National Park Service, NCL's published materials, and the firsthand traveler entries in this site's port logbooks. Where a number couldn't be confirmed against a source like that, it isn't asserted here.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card, cruise-line and embassy numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake's** PWA. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

This pack is written for first-time Alaska cruisers and solo cruisers in Kristie's group. NCL Bliss is one of the strongest solo-cabin ships afloat (no single supplement on Studios, dedicated Studio Lounge, built-in solo cohort), and Alaska in July is the Inside Passage at its best — long daylight, green mountains, glaciers within reach, the small towns of southeast Alaska in their summer high season.

If this is also your very first cruise of any kind, the **first-cruise guide** is a useful read alongside this pack. If you've sailed before and are wondering what's different about NCL specifically (Freestyle Dining, Studio Lounge culture, no formal nights), Section 1 below covers it.

At a Glance

Ship	Norwegian Bliss
Cruise line	Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
Class	Breakaway Plus — sister to Norwegian Joy, Encore, and (functionally) Escape
Specifications	168,028 GT · 1,094 ft / 333 m · 20 decks · 4,002 guests double occupancy · ~1,700 crew
Year built	2018 (delivered April 21, 2018 — Meyer Werft, Papenburg, Germany); Bahamas registry
Distinctive feature	The Wyland-painted humpback whale on the hull — NCL has commissioned hull art since 2002 and named-artist murals since 2013 (Peter Max on Breakaway, Guy Harvey on Escape); Bliss carries the line's first and only Wyland, and it remains the signature visual of the class
Departure port	Bell Street Cruise Terminal (Pier 66), 2225 Alaskan Way, Seattle , Washington

Itinerary	7 nights / 8 days · Alaska round-trip (“Seattle Closed Loop”)
Sailing dates	Saturday July 11 – Saturday July 18, 2026
Audience	Solo travelers (hosted group) — first-time and experienced
Group host (on board)	Kristie McClung Escoe — runs the in-person rhythm, dining, sailaway meetup
Travel agent (booking & inclusions)	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co. — booked the group rate; the source of truth for what’s bundled (Free at Sea perks, etc.)
Group rhythm	“Get Acquainted” dinner Friday 7/10 at Currant Bistro (Sound Hotel Belltown); Sail Away at Sea View Bar Deck 17; group dinner Sat 7/11 at 5:00 PM (venue: confirm with Kristie); specialty dining Sun/Tue/Wed (Teppanyaki, Cagney’s, Le Bistro). Full schedule in Section 9 .
Group rates	Solo Studio Cabin from \$1,269 (no single supplement). Verify other categories with Kristie.
Currency aboard	US Dollar

Ports of call

The verified day-by-day for the July 11, 2026 sailing (sourced from gangwaze.com and cross-checked with cruisemapper + alaskacruises.com):

Day	Date	Stop	Arrival	Departure
1	Sat Jul 11	Seattle	—	4:00 PM
2	Sun Jul 12	At sea (Pacific run toward Sitka)	—	—
3	Mon Jul 13	Sitka	10:00 AM	6:00 PM

Day	Date	Stop	Arrival	Departure
4	Tue Jul 14	Juneau then Endicott Arm / Dawes Glacier scenic cruising same afternoon	6:30 AM	1:30 PM (Juneau); scenic cruising follows
5	Wed Jul 15	Icy Strait Point / Hoonah	6:00 AM	3:00 PM
6	Thu Jul 16	Ketchikan / Ward Cove <i>(Bliss docks at Ward Cove, ~7 mi north of downtown — shuttle required; see Day 6)</i>	6:00 AM	1:15 PM
7	Fri Jul 17	Victoria BC (the itinerary's required foreign port; short evening stop)	8:00 PM	11:59 PM
8	Sat Jul 18	Seattle — disembark	7:00 AM	—

Notable: Juneau and Dawes Glacier share Day 4. The ship departs Juneau 1:30 PM and proceeds into Endicott Arm; Dawes Glacier approach is afternoon-into-evening. Kristie's Cagney's Steakhouse 5:30 PM group dinner that night sits in the middle of scenic-cruising time — see Day 4.

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Section 1 — Your Ship: Norwegian Bliss



Norwegian Bliss anchored off Portland, Dorset — the Robert Wyland humpback whale mural visible on the bow, the Aqua Park waterslides on the upper deck. Photo by Andrew Bone via Flickr, CC BY 2.0

A purpose-built Alaska ship

Norwegian Bliss was delivered on April 21, 2018 by Meyer Werft at Papenburg, Germany — the third ship of NCL's **Breakaway Plus class** (after Norwegian Escape 2015 and Norwegian Joy 2017). She was **purpose-designed for Alaska**: NCL built her with wraparound observation decks and what the line billed at her debut as the largest observation lounge in its fleet (Deck 15 forward), and gave her hull to marine-life artist **Wyland** — the muralist behind the “Whaling Walls” — for a humpback-whale mural that wraps the bow. NCL has carried hull art since 2002 and named-artist murals since Peter Max painted Norwegian Breakaway in 2013; the Wyland whale is Bliss's own. By your July 2026 sailing she's eight years into service — well past any new-ship issues, her crew rhythms long settled.

Her direct sisters are Norwegian Joy (2017) and Norwegian Encore (2019). Norwegian Escape (2015) is the same hull but technically the lead ship of the original Breakaway Plus class, sometimes counted separately. If you've sailed Joy or Encore, Bliss feels familiar; if you've sailed older Breakaway-class ships (Breakaway, Getaway), Bliss is the bigger, more refined version.

Worth opening on your phone before you sail: **video walkthroughs** of her public spaces, **logbook entries** from travelers who've sailed her, and the **deck plans** so the first day's wayfinding is less guesswork.

What's distinctive about Bliss

She's a ship designed around **outdoor observation** — which matches Alaska perfectly. The signature features:

- **Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — NCL's largest. Floor-to-ceiling windows wrapping the bow, indoor seating, a coffee bar, books, board games. Open all day; the quietest place on the ship in the early morning. This is where most Alaska cruisers spend their best hours.

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- **Sea View Bar** (Deck 17) — open-air bar with panoramic views; less crowded than the main pool deck. (*This is where Kristie is holding the group's sailaway — see Section 9.*)
 - **Aqua Park** with the **Ocean Loops** double-loop trap-door waterslide (159 ft above the sea, the loops extend 11 ft beyond the hull), plus the **Aqua Racer** mat slide and the **Free Fall** drop slides. Free; lines build by mid-morning on sea days.
 - **Galaxy Pavilion** — interactive arcade and VR experiences (paid extra).
 - **The Cavern Club** — Beatles tribute venue; full original-set songs by a resident band.
 - **Headliners Comedy Club** — late-night comedy in a small-room setting.
 - **The Haven** — NCL's ship-within-a-ship luxury enclave with private restaurant, courtyard, pool, and lounge.

What's NOT on Bliss (because she's Breakaway Plus, not Prima Plus): no Ocean Boulevard 360 wraparound (that's a Prima-class feature), no infinity pools. The closest visual equivalent is the Waterfront on Deck 8 — a partial outdoor promenade with bars and seating.

Cabin categories — the solo calculus

Before you commit, run the stateroom sanity check — a four-question filter that catches the bookings most likely to leave a cruiser unhappy. For Alaska specifically, the balcony-vs-interior question hits hardest because the trip is partly scenic-cruising; if you'd regret not having a balcony for Dawes Glacier, the filter tells you.

NCL's signature solo offering is at its strongest on Bliss: dedicated **Studio cabins** with **no single supplement**, **Studio Lounge access** (free coffee, social space, scheduled hosted hours for solo cruisers), and a built-in cohort of fellow solos. Studio cabins are roughly 100 sq ft and windowless — compact and efficient.

Decision rule for the July 11 sailing (group rates):

- **Solo Studio Cabin (\$1,269)** — the flyer-advertised rate. Best value for solo cruisers who'll spend daylight hours off the ship or in public spaces. Studio Lounge is your social anchor.

- **Oceanview / Balcony / Mini-Suite / Suite** — verify category and pricing with Kristie. Most other categories don't waive the single supplement, so the solo-traveler value drops sharply above Studio.
- **The Haven** — NCL's premium enclave with private restaurant, lounge, and pool. Real if budget allows, but a different experience; the Haven cabins are unconnected to the Studio Lounge culture, so you'd be opting out of the built-in solo community.

For Alaska specifically, the **balcony argument** is real: the ship spends hours threading the Inside Passage; a private outdoor space earns its keep. But the Studio cabin + Observation Lounge combo covers the same need with less spend.

For ship-size context, the **Ship Size Atlas** lets you compare Bliss to other ships. Follow her live position throughout your week via the **Ship Logbook** — a small comfort if family ashore wants to know where you are.

Dining

Bliss runs NCL's **Freestyle Dining** model — no fixed dining-room assignment, no traditional set seating; you eat where and when you want within the included venues, with specialty restaurants available at additional cost.

Included main dining: - **Manhattan Room** (Deck 7 aft) — main dining room with a small dance floor and live music most evenings; the most atmospheric of the included options. - **Taste** and **Savor** (Deck 6) — paired main dining rooms with identical menus; slightly more efficient on busy nights. - **Garden Café** (Deck 16) — buffet; long hours; an upper-deck view that earns its keep in Alaska. - **The Local Bar & Grill** — pub-style, 24-hour favorites.

Specialty restaurants (paid extra):

- **Cagney's Steakhouse** — NCL's signature steakhouse. (*Kristie's group dines here Tuesday 7/14, 5:30 PM — see Section 9.*)
- **Le Bistro** — French. (*Kristie's group dines here Wednesday 7/15, 5:45 PM.*)
- **Teppanyaki** — Japanese teppanyaki room. (*Kristie's group dines here Sunday 7/12, 5:00 PM.*)
- **Q Texas Smokehouse** — barbecue.
- **Los Lobos** — Mexican.

- **Food Republic** — small-plate concept; Pan-Asian.
- **Ocean Blue** — seafood; the priciest specialty.
- **La Cucina** — Italian; the included-or-light-cover option on Bliss (Onda by Scarpetta is a Prima-class concept, not on Bliss).

Bars worth knowing:

- **Atrium Bar** — Deck 6/7 atrium; the daytime social anchor.
- **Maltings Whiskey Bar** — Deck 7; quieter, specialty whiskey + flights.
- **Sugarcane Mojito Bar** — Deck 7; pre-dinner cocktails.
- **Bliss Ultra Lounge** — Deck 7 aft; late-night dance club.
- **Spice H2O** — adults-only deck aft pool/bar; quiet by day, party-feel by night.
- **Waves Pool Bar** — main pool deck.
- **Observation Lounge** coffee bar (Deck 15 forward) — coffee, books, the all-day Alaska anchor.
- **Studio Lounge** (Studio cabin guests only) — host-led solo gatherings.
- **Haven Lounge** and **Haven Restaurant** — for Haven suite guests only.

A **Specialty Dining Package** (3 or 5 meals) prepaid in the Cruise Planner is good value if you'd dine specialty 3+ times anyway. Since Kristie has booked three group specialty nights (Teppanyaki, Cagney's, Le Bistro), a 3-meal package may already cover the group dinners if you're attending all three. Run the math in the **cruise-budget-calculator**.

Drinks

NCL's drink-package math: the Premium Beverage Package is commonly included in the **"Free at Sea"** promotional bundle when booking. If your group fare included Free at Sea, drinks may already be covered — **verify what's bundled with Tina Maulsby at Maulsby Travel Co.** (the travel agent who booked the group; she's the source of truth for inclusions, not Kristie). Otherwise the package runs ~\$109/day per person + 20% gratuity at pre-cruise rates; breaks even at ~5–6 drinks per day. For solo cruisers without heavy drinking habits, pay-as-you-go often pencils out better. The **drink-calculator** lets you put in your real consumption pattern. The companion article **Is the**

drink package worth it? walks through the breakeven math with worked examples — Alaska in particular is an itinerary where port days don't lend themselves to drinking from breakfast, which shifts the math.

Section 2 — Day by Day

Day-by-day below uses the most-common NCL Bliss Alaska itinerary. **Verify your specific day order in the NCL app** — the published sequence sometimes shifts between sailings.

Day 0 — Friday, July 10 — Seattle (pre-cruise, optional)

Kristie has set a **“Get Acquainted” dinner Friday evening** for group members who arrive a day early:

- **8:30 PM:** Group gathers at **Currant Bistro** inside the **Sound Hotel Seattle Belltown** (2120 4th Ave, Seattle, WA 98121). Appetizer plates and drinks available for purchase; you order what you want.
- **9:30 – 11:00 PM:** Happy hour rolls into a casual get-to-know-each-other session.

The Sound Hotel is in Belltown, about 5 blocks from Pier 66 (~10 minute walk if you're staying nearby). Currant Bistro is the hotel's all-day American/small-plates restaurant — casual, not a reservation-required specialty venue. **Confirm with Kristie whether she's holding a table for the group** (likely à la carte; the format Kristie described — “appetizer plates and drinks for purchase” — sounds like a casual show-up-and-order setup). If you want a seat near the group, arriving 10–15 minutes early helps.

Where to stay Friday night: The Sound Hotel Belltown is the convenient choice (you're already there for dinner), but anywhere in Belltown, Downtown, or near Pike Place puts you within walking distance of the terminal Saturday morning. Verify Friday's dinner attendance with Kristie if you want a seat reserved.

Day 1 — Saturday, July 11 — Seattle (embarkation)



Seattle skyline at twilight from Kerry Park

Terminal: Bell Street Cruise Terminal at Pier 66 — 2225 Alaskan Way, Seattle. Different terminal from the Pier 91 used by RCL/Princess/HAL; Pier 66 is the working downtown terminal, an easy walk from Pike Place Market, the Seattle Aquarium, and the Great Wheel. About 30–40 minutes from Sea-Tac (SEA) by Uber/Lyft.

If you're driving to Pier 66. The **Bell Street Pier garage** directly across from the terminal has 1,700 covered, secure spaces at ~\$33/day (Republic Parking; max vehicle height 6'6"; 25 handicap stalls; reservable in advance). Most Bliss cruisers fly into Sea-Tac, but if you're driving from Seattle, Tacoma, or the Pacific Northwest, Bell Street Pier is the convenient choice. Offsite long-term lots near Sea-Tac with shuttle service can run cheaper but add ~45 min each way to your embarkation morning — Pier 66's on-terminal garage is usually the right call for a week-long stay.

Embark window: 11:30 AM – 3:00 PM. Ship departs ~4:00 PM. **You must be back at the terminal by 2:00 PM** to complete embarkation processing.

The Saturday morning routine Kristie laid out:

NCL allows **early luggage drop-off from 8:00 AM** at the terminal — so you can drop bags, then enjoy a few hours of Seattle before boarding.

- **Option 1 (longer Pike Place):** Drop luggage 8–9 AM → walk ~12 minutes to **Biscuit Bitch Belltown** (2303 3rd Ave, open Sat 8 AM – 3 PM) for breakfast (cult-favorite breakfast biscuits) → walk to **Pike Place Market** to explore → back to the

terminal by 2 PM. *Note: Biscuit Bitch has a downtown sister location (621 3rd Ave) that's closed; the Belltown shop is the active one.*

- **Option 2 (Pike Place first):** Drop luggage 8–9 AM → walk straight to **Pike Place Market** — breakfast vendors and fresh produce/seafood stalls open from **7 AM**; farm tables 9 AM – 4 PM; craft market 11 AM – 4 PM; most of the market is active 10 AM – 5 PM → continue exploring waterfront, the Seattle Aquarium, or the museums district → back by 2 PM.

Either option works. Pike Place is at its quietest before 9 AM (good if you want to walk through without crowds); the flying-fish performance gets going around 11.

For deeper Seattle pre-cruise reading: the **Seattle port page** covers the broader picture, and the **Seattle logbook** collects what other cruisers thought of their embarkation-day morning.

The realistic Day 1 timeline:

- **8:00 AM – 9:00 AM:** Early luggage drop-off if you're using it.
- **9:00 AM – 1:00 PM:** Seattle morning (Option 1 or 2 above).
- **1:30 – 2:00 PM:** Return to Pier 66 with margin.
- **2:00 PM:** All-aboard begins for late-embarkation guests; lines at security may build.
- **2:30 PM:** Find your cabin (cabins typically open by 1 PM; if you boarded earlier, they're ready now). Meet your stateroom steward.
- **3:30 PM:** Mandatory muster drill — NCL's drill is partly app-based (watch the safety video in the NCL app) plus an in-person check-in at your assigned station.
- **4:00 PM: Sailaway at the Sea View Bar, Deck 17.** *Kristie is here.* Less-crowded than the main pool deck; panoramic views; she'll be passing out the week's printed info. If you want sailaway outside first, come find her at Sea View afterward.
- **5:00 PM: Group dinner reservation** — check with Kristie for the venue. Open to anyone who wants to join.
- **Later evening:** NCL hosts a **solo-group meet-and-greet** sometime on Day 1 — Kristie will share the time once NCL confirms it.

What to pack in your carry-on for Day 1: swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive), light jacket (Seattle evenings can be 60°F even in July), all medications, change of clothes, passport (preferred — Victoria BC on Day 7 is a foreign port), phone charger, refillable water bottle, your printed group itinerary if Kristie sent one. Your checked bags may not arrive until 7–9 PM.

Money/card: Your NCL keycard is your ID, room key, and onboard charge. You'll receive it at check-in. Currency aboard: US Dollar.

Day 2 — Sunday, July 12 — At sea, the Pacific run toward Sitka

A sea day. The settling-in day; the group's rhythm starts taking shape.

A route note worth knowing: Sitka faces the open ocean — it sits on the outer coast of Baranof Island, not inside the protected channels. To reach it from Seattle, the ship runs up the Pacific side of Vancouver Island and across open water. Today is the most ocean-exposed day of the week (see **Section 7** if motion is a concern), and the scenery is open horizon rather than close-in fjord walls. The threading-the-channels Inside Passage scenery arrives mid-week, between the Alaska ports.

Morning: - Coffee in the **Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — the day's best move. Quiet, panoramic, the first hour after sunrise has the best light. - Breakfast at the **Garden Café** (buffet, busier) or **Taste/Savor** (sit-down, calmer).

Mid-morning to lunch — pick ONE:

- **The Studio Lounge** if you're in a Studio cabin — Day-2 morning is often when the hosted Studio coffee hour happens; check the daily program.
- **The Mandara Spa thermal-suite day pass** — sea-day mornings are when introductory rates appear.
- **Ocean Loops** waterslide (and the Aqua Park siblings) — first thing has the shortest lines.
- **A bridge tour or behind-the-scenes ship tour** if the Cruise Planner offers it.

Afternoon: - The open-ocean run is its own show — horizon, seabirds, and a real chance of whale spouts off the west coast of Vancouver Island. The Observation Lounge or your balcony. - Trivia, lectures, activities on the daily program.

Evening — group specialty dining:

- **5:00 PM: Teppanyaki.** Kristie's group has a reservation for whoever's joining. Teppanyaki is the showy hibachi-style room; arrive 5–10 minutes early to be seated together.

Day 3 — Monday, July 13 — Sitka, Alaska

Sitka harbor in a Library of Congress archive photograph — the town's Russian-Tlingit heritage shows in any era

Arrival: 10:00 AM. **Depart:** 6:00 PM. Bliss docks at the **Sitka Sound Cruise Terminal** at Halibut Point, about 5 miles north of downtown — no tendering. A **free shuttle** runs continuously between the terminal and downtown (330 Harbor Drive) during port hours; the ride is 10–15 minutes. The terminal manages boarding with a reservation system on busy days (reserve at reservation.sitkadock.com, or use the standby line), and **the last shuttle leaves downtown 30 minutes before all-aboard** — build that into your afternoon.

Sitka — the most historically dense port of the week. Capital of Russian America from 1808 until the 1867 sale of Alaska to the United States; the first Russian Orthodox cathedral in North America (St. Michael's, rebuilt after a 1966 fire); deep Tlingit history that shaped its first centuries before Russian contact. Most Alaska itineraries skip Sitka in favor of Ketchikan; **this itinerary covers both** — take

advantage. The walkable downtown is small (under a mile end-to-end) and the **Sitka National Historical Park** totem trail is among the most affecting easy walks in southeast Alaska.

Free, walkable once the shuttle drops you downtown:

- **St. Michael's Cathedral** — the rebuilt Russian Orthodox cathedral (small donation suggested for entry).
- **Sitka National Historical Park** — totem-pole trail through old-growth forest, 30-minute walk from downtown. Free entry. The Tlingit and Russian-era exhibits at the visitor center are quietly excellent.
- **Sheldon Jackson Museum** — Alaska's oldest museum; one of the best ethnographic collections of Alaska Native material culture in the state.

Paid (decide ahead):

- **Sea otter and wildlife boat tour** (~\$210–225/person) — Sitka has the densest sea-otter population in southeast Alaska. The top-rated operator is **True Alaskan Tours'** “**Sitka Whale Watch and Sea Otter Quest**” (2-hour tour, Alaska Native-owned, ~\$210).
- **Fortress of the Bear** sanctuary — rescued bears in semi-natural habitat. **\$20 adult / \$15 ship crew** self-guided admission; ethically run, not a roadside zoo. (Packaged shore-excursion tours bundling Fortress + Raptor Center + transport run \$50–80.)
- **Russian Bishop's House tour** — NPS, **free admission** (inside the National Historical Park); ranger-led upper-floor tours also free, ticket at the front desk.
- **Independent transit: The RIDE Sitka** runs a \$5 day pass / \$2 one-way between downtown, the park, and the Industrial Park area. Note: the Blue Line (Sawmill Creek Rd) stops at Gary Paxton Industrial Park, a 5–10 min walk short of Fortress of the Bear — plan the walk. (The terminal-to-downtown leg is covered by the free terminal shuttle; The RIDE is for getting beyond downtown.)

Pack for Sitka: rain jacket (Sitka rains 220+ days per year — your day might be one), waterproof or treated walking shoes, fleece layer, \$30–50 cash USD for transit and tips.

Monday evening is open — no group specialty dinner tonight. Solo cruisers tend to land at the **Studio Lounge**, **Sea View Bar** (Deck 17, where Kristie hosted sailaway), or the **Observation Lounge** for pre- and post-dinner gatherings. Check the daily Freestyle Daily program for Monday-night theatre and live-music options.

Worth a look on the way in: the **Sitka port page**, its **photo gallery**, and the **Sitka logbook** — what other travelers noticed at the totem trail, around St. Michael's, on the transit-bus loop. Build your day in the **Port Day Planner** before you go ashore; record what actually happened in the **Port Logbook** on the way back.

Day 4 — Tuesday, July 14 — Juneau in the morning, Dawes Glacier in the afternoon



Juneau seen from Mount Roberts, with cruise ships docked along the waterfront

Two stops in one day. Plan accordingly.

- **Juneau:** 6:30 AM arrival, **1:30 PM departure** — about 6.5 hours ashore. Early start; you'll want to be off the ship by 7:30 AM to make the most of it.
- **Endicott Arm / Dawes Glacier:** scenic cruising from ~3:00 PM into the evening — the ship turns into the fjord shortly after leaving Juneau and approaches the

glacier face by late afternoon / early evening. No off-ship excursion; the day's second half is what you see from deck.

Juneau — the only U.S. state capital you can't reach by road. Reachable only by ship, plane, or float plane. Population ~32,000 year-round; ~17,000 daily cruise passengers in peak summer. Downtown is built into a near-vertical mountainside; the Mount Roberts Tramway is the up-the-mountain ride most cruisers take.

Free, walkable from the cruise dock:

- **Downtown Juneau** — South Franklin Street's bars, the Red Dog Saloon (touristy but historic), state-museum-quality Sealaska Heritage Institute (free; among the best Alaska Native cultural exhibits in the state), Alaska State Capitol (free 30-minute tours weekdays).
- **Last Chance Mining Museum** — short walk uphill, free, gold-mining history.

Paid (decide ahead — the early all-aboard at 1:00 PM is tight; book a half-day, not a full day):

- **Mendenhall Glacier visit** — the glacier is 13 miles from downtown. **M&M Tours' "Glacier Express" (mmtoursofjuneau.com)** is now a **\$79 adult round-trip 3-hour tour** (transport + 2 hours at the visitor center, Nugget Falls walk, glacier viewpoints). NCL ship excursion ~\$80–120. The old "Blue Bus" shuttle-only rate is no longer the product offering; this is a full tour.
- **Mount Roberts Tramway (Goldbelt Tram)** — 1,800-foot vertical tram up Mount Roberts; **\$65 adult all-day pass** (Goldbelt no longer sells a round-trip-only ticket). Easy hiking trails at the top. The base station is right at the cruise dock, which makes it the easiest thing to combine with anything else on this short Juneau morning.
- **Whale watching** — humpback season peaks June–September. **Harv & Marv's (harvandmarvs.com)** runs out of Auke Bay; among the highest-quality wildlife excursions on this itinerary. **\$159–210/person**. *Tour is ~4 hours total (1 hr transfer + 3 hr on water). The earliest morning slot (typically 7:30 AM pickup) is the only one that fits the 1:30 PM all-aboard with margin — confirm the departure slot at booking.* **Dress for it like glacier viewing, not like a port walk** — a 28-foot boat at 20 knots in 55°F air feels like 35°F at the rail, and humpback breach-splash carries 20 feet. Full layers, waterproof shell, hat that won't blow off, hand warmers, non-slip shoes. Cold fumbles ruin breach photos.

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- **Helicopter to Juneau Icefield + glacier landing — TEMSCO (temscoair.com)** is the local operator. Mendenhall guided glacier walk from ~\$409; Pilot's Choice (2 glacier landings on the Juneau Icefield) from ~\$579; dog-sledding combo from ~\$699. *Verify the morning slot fits the 1:30 PM ship-back call.*

For first-timers given the short Juneau day: Mendenhall Glacier via the Glacier Express (\$79, 3 hours door-to-door) is the highest-value half-day, and it leaves time for the Mount Roberts tram at the dock afterward. If you want to splurge on whale watching instead, take a confirmed early-morning trip; afternoon trips don't fit — and doing both the glacier and the whales doesn't fit either (7+ hours of touring against 6.5 ashore). Pick one.

Then — Dawes Glacier in the afternoon and evening.

The ship enters **Endicott Arm**, a 30-mile fjord south of Juneau, and approaches the face of **Dawes Glacier**. The Captain typically narrates entry to the fjord; naturalists may be on the PA system at the glacier face.



Endicott Arm fjord with floating ice from the Dawes Glacier face

Approximate timing (varies by sailing): - ~3:00 PM: Ship enters Stephens Passage, turns into Endicott Arm. - ~4:30–6:30 PM: Approach to Dawes Glacier face. Ship holds position 0.5–1.0 nautical miles off — the safety distance is set by ice-fall risk. - ~7:00 PM: Reverse out of the fjord; cruising resumes overnight toward Icy Strait Point.

Calving (large pieces of ice breaking off and crashing into the sea) is unpredictable but common; the sound carries half a mile. Dress for cold — the fjord traps cold air, even in summer wind chills can drop into the 30s°F at the rail. The glacier face creates its own micro-climate: Endicott Arm typically runs 10–15°F colder than Juneau two hours earlier, which is why you'll feel underdressed at the rail even if you were comfortable downtown that morning.

Best viewing locations on Bliss:

- **Your own balcony** (warm coffee, your own pace) if you have one.
- **Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — heated, glass-roofed, the best of both worlds.
- **Sea View Bar** (Deck 17, where Kristie holds sailaway) — open-air, panoramic.
- **Deck 8 Waterfront** — open to the bow but cold and windy.

Pack for the glacier afternoon: thermal layer, fleece, waterproof shell, hat, gloves, scarf, **air-activated hand warmers** (1–2 pairs in your pockets — for static deck viewing they're the difference between two hours of comfort and two hours of suffering), hot coffee in a thermal mug, binoculars (rent on board if you don't have your own), camera or phone with battery topped up (cold drains them fast).

Kristie's Cagney's Steakhouse 5:30 PM group dinner is RIGHT in the middle of the Dawes Glacier approach window. Real choice tonight: hold the dinner reservation (Cagney's is a 90-minute commitment) and accept that you'll see less of the glacier face from the indoor dining room; OR step out of dinner mid-meal if the Captain announces calving activity; OR have a quick dinner elsewhere earlier and prioritize the glacier. Cagney's Deck 8 has SOME windows but isn't an Observation Lounge view. Discuss with Kristie if you want to suggest a later seating.

Background reading for this two-stop day: the **Juneau port page**, its **logbook entries**, and the **Endicott Arm scenic-cruising page** — the **Endicott Arm gallery** is the closest thing to a preview of what the Captain will narrate at the glacier face.

Day 5 — Wednesday, July 15 — Icy Strait Point, Alaska



Huna Tlingit cultural performance at Icy Strait Point — the contemporary expression of the village's pre-contact heritage

Arrival: 6:00 AM. **Depart:** 3:00 PM. Bliss docks — no tendering. Icy Strait Point has two berths: the original cannery-side **Adventure Landing** floating pier and **Wilderness Landing**, the deep-water dock the Huna Totem Corporation built in partnership with NCL specifically so mega-ships could come alongside. The free **Transporter Gondola** (a 4–5 minute enclosed ride, distinct from the paid SkyGlider) and walking paths connect Wilderness Landing to the cannery and beach areas.

Icy Strait Point is a built-for-cruising port with a real village behind it. A modest cruise destination on Chichagof Island, adjacent to the village of **Hoonah** (population ~930, 2020 census), the largest Tlingit settlement in Alaska. The cruise port was built around a restored 1912 salmon cannery, with the Huna Tlingit tribal corporation as the principal owner and operator. The **World's Largest ZipRider** (5,330 feet, ~1,300 ft vertical drop) is the signature Icy Strait Point excursion. Unlike Sitka or Juneau, this is a port purpose-built for cruise visits — no large downtown to wander.

Free or low-cost, walkable:

- **Cannery Museum** — restored 1912 cannery building (the big red Hoonah Packing Co. structure at the Cannery Dock); cultural and industrial history. Free.

- **Hoonah Village walk** — ~1.6-mile flat walk into the village along the waterfront road (~30 min); small museum, Russian Orthodox church, the Hoonah Indian Association heritage building.
- **Beach walks** — the gravel/cobble shoreline; quiet; eagle-watching common.

Paid (decide ahead):

- **World's Largest ZipRider** — \$199 walk-up; the marketing name is “Largest” though it is also the longest single-drop zip. Three minutes of flight; once-in-a-lifetime. **Book via NCL pre-cruise or walk-up at the port** — this isn't a Viator product. Reserve early; the line is real on a Bliss-sized ship.
- **Whale watching** — Icy Strait is one of the best whale-watching waters in southeast Alaska; humpback feeding grounds. ~\$150–180/person via large-operator Viator listings; small-boat 14-passenger options also exist and tend to be the stronger experience.
- **Chichagof Island Tour: Brown Bear Search** (~\$163, ~3-hour van tour) — Chichagof has one of the highest brown-bear densities in the world. Tours go inland to bear-frequented salmon streams.
- **Tribal Dance & Cultural Legends** (~\$25) at the Heritage Center Theater — Huna Tlingit performance. Sold direct at the port or via cruise line; not a Viator product.

For first-timers in Icy Strait Point: the ZipRider if you want the drop, or whale watching for the wildlife. The ship-built nature of the port means there's less “wander town” than at Sitka/Juneau — plan an excursion or settle in for a peaceful beach-and-cannery afternoon.

Worth a look on the way in: the **Icy Strait Point port page**, its **Huna Tlingit gallery**, and the **ISP logbook** — the heritage notes from other travelers give Hoonah's pre-contact history depth the cannery-museum brochure doesn't. Build your day in the **Port Day Planner**; log it in the **Port Logbook** on the way back.

Tonight is Le Bistro 5:45 PM — the easiest of the three group specialty nights to make on time. ISP departs 3:00 PM; you have ~2:45 to shower, change, and walk to Deck 6. The pace after a brisk ISP day is a good fit for Le Bistro's slower French rhythm.

Day 6 — Thursday, July 16 — Ketchikan / Ward Cove, Alaska



Ketchikan waterfront in a Fisher Studio archive photograph — the town's salmon-canning heritage in sepia

Arrival: 6:00 AM (early). **Depart:** 1:15 PM (early). This is the shortest port day of the week — 7 hours dock-to-dock with the shuttle ride eating into both ends. Plan a single focused excursion, not two.

Read this first about Ward Cove. NCL holds a long-term preferential docking arrangement at **Ward Cove**, ~7 miles north of downtown Ketchikan. Norwegian Bliss berths there — **not** at the main downtown pier most cruise ships use. To reach downtown Creek Street, Saxman, or the Lumberjack Show, you'll take **NCL's complimentary shuttle**, which runs continuously every 15–20 minutes and drops at Berth 4 downtown (near Safeway, about a 15-minute walk to Creek Street). The one-way shuttle ride is 20–30 minutes; build margin for the all-aboard return.

Ketchikan — the “salmon capital of the world” and the southernmost major town in Alaska. Population ~8,200. The town clings to a narrow shelf between mountains and the Tongass Narrows. Wood-plank Creek Street (a stilted boardwalk over Ketchikan Creek) was the historical red-light district; today it's preserved as a shopping/walking area with a salmon-spawning creek running beneath. The world's largest collection of standing **totem poles** is split between Saxman Native Village (south of downtown) and Totem Bight State Historical Park (north — closer to Ward Cove).

Plan on rain. Ketchikan averages ~150 inches of rain a year — among the wettest cities in the United States, and three times what Juneau gets. On any given July afternoon, the boardwalks, dock approaches, and Creek Street planks are wet whether the sky is open or not. Waterproof shoes with grip matter more here than at any other port on the itinerary; the wet wood is treacherously slick. A hooded shell, not an umbrella — Ketchikan’s funnel-wind off the Tongass Narrows turns umbrellas inside out fast.

From Ward Cove (walkable or short-shuttle):

- **Ward Cove venue** — by 2026, the **Great Alaskan Lumberjack Show** runs a Ward Cove venue in addition to its downtown location. If you’d rather skip the shuttle for the show, the Ward Cove venue is right there. \$37/adult.

Downtown (via NCL shuttle):

- **Creek Street** — the iconic boardwalk; restaurants, shops, the historic Dolly’s House Museum (\$10, **cash only**). Salmon visible in the creek in season.
- **Totem Heritage Center** — short walk from the downtown drop-off; \$7 entry (adult), \$6 senior, free under 13. Nationally significant totem collection.
- **Lumberjack Show** (\$37 adult / \$18.50 child) — touristy and well-rated; right by the downtown dock if you want a downtown ticket.

Paid (decide ahead):

- **Saxman Native Village** (\$90–230 cruise-style packaged tours; standalone Cape Fox Dancers performance is cheaper if booked at the village directly) — Tlingit cultural village 2.5 miles south of downtown; totem park + carving studio + dance performance. The Viator product to look for is “**Saxman Native Village and Ketchikan Highlights**” (often bundled with the Lumberjack Show).
- **Totem Bight State Park** — totem park 10 miles north of downtown (closer to Ward Cove); less crowded than Saxman; quieter walking. **Park entry \$5/person** May–Sep. Cab from downtown is **\$60–75 one-way**; the Blue Line public bus runs Mon–Fri only for \$1–2 if you want the budget alternative. From Ward Cove the cab is shorter but no specific fare is published.
- **Misty Fjords flightseeing** (\$309–500) — small floatplane to the fjords inland. The Ketchikan splurge worth saving for. Strong direct operators: **Island Wings Air Service, Carlin Air, Misty Fjords Air**. Floatplane departures from downtown.

For first-timers in Ketchikan (Ward Cove-docked): allow ~45 min round-trip on the shuttle to reach downtown. A focused half-day is Creek Street + Totem Heritage Center + the Lumberjack Show. Misty Fjords flightseeing is the splurge if budget allows; plan tightly because the shuttle and the all-aboard call don't forgive late returns.

Worth a look on the way in: the **Ketchikan port page**, its **photo gallery** (the sepia Fisher Studio panoramas are worth a slow scroll), and the **Ketchikan logbook** — other travelers' notes on Saxman vs. Totem Bight, Misty Fjords operators, and the Ward Cove shuttle reality. The **Port Day Planner** earns its keep here given the tight Thu schedule; **log the day** when you're back on board.

Thursday evening is open — no group specialty dinner tonight. With the 1:15 PM ship-back call and a long afternoon at sea before Victoria, this is the week's most relaxed evening. The **Studio Lounge**, **Observation Lounge**, and **Sea View Bar** tend to fill with solo cruisers around sunset; the **Manhattan Room** has live music most nights if you want a longer dinner on your own pace.

Day 7 — Friday, July 17 — Victoria, British Columbia



Victoria's Inner Harbour at night — Parliament Buildings illuminated

Arrival: 8:00 PM. **Depart:** 11:59 PM. **A short evening stop** — just under 4 hours dock-to-dock, of which 30 min each end is shuttle and security. Realistic shore time: 2.5 hours.

Why Victoria is on every Seattle-Alaska itinerary. The **Passenger Vessel Services Act of 1886** prohibits foreign-flag ships (Bliss is Bahamian-flagged, like most large cruise ships) from carrying passengers between two U.S. ports without calling at a foreign port in between. Seattle to Sitka, Juneau, Icy Strait Point, and Ketchikan is otherwise five U.S. ports in a row. Victoria is the nearest foreign port to Seattle, and the late-evening stop is the shortest, cheapest way for the line to satisfy the law on the way home. Every Seattle-Alaska sailing on every line makes this same call for this same reason — which is why the stop is short and why nobody's brochure explains it.

The ship docks at the **Ogden Point** breakwater, ~3 km from downtown. Free shuttle buses or a \$10 round-trip cab/rideshare run between Ogden Point and the Inner Harbour.

Victoria — the trip's late-night punctuation mark. Provincial capital of British Columbia; a small city of Edwardian bones — Edwardian architecture, the Empress Hotel, the Royal BC Museum (closed by the time you arrive), the famous **Butchart Gardens** 30 minutes outside town. The 8 PM – midnight slot limits realistic options: this is a walk-the-Inner-Harbour-at-night stop, not a half-day excursion.

Realistic 2.5-hour evening options:

- **Inner Harbour walk** — the iconic Parliament Buildings are lit up at night and worth seeing; the Empress Hotel exterior; harbor walking path; totem poles at Thunderbird Park. Quietly the best use of a short Victoria stop.
- **Dinner at a downtown pub or bistro** — a real Canadian dinner ashore is a small treat to close the week.
- **Butchart Gardens with evening lighting** — gardens stay open until 10:00 PM Wed–Sun in summer (Jul 17 is a Friday, so they're open); lighting is theatrical. **CA\$44.25 adult admission incl. tax** + transport ~\$60 round-trip. Tight to fit in 2.5 hours including transit. Worth it only if you commit early and accept rushing.
- **Gray Line Evening CitySights (Hop on Hop off)** — ~\$50 adult, 40-minute narrated evening loop (not the 90-min daytime Hop-On version, which has a 5:30 PM last departure and won't run). Gray Line's evening summer 2026 schedule is being finalized — verify the specific July 17 departure at booking.

The Royal BC Museum closes 5 PM daily and is therefore not available on this 8 PM arrival. (Worth the trip on a different Victoria visit.)

Currency: Canadian dollars are local; USD widely accepted near the harbor; credit/debit cards universal — you don't need to exchange.

For first-timers in Victoria: this short stop is the trip's gentle decompression. A walk through Inner Harbour at night and a quiet dinner ashore covers it. Save Butchart Gardens for a longer Victoria-specific trip.

Worth a look before you tender in: the **Victoria BC port page**, its **evening-harbour gallery**, and the **Victoria logbook** — what other Alaska-cruise travelers actually did with a short evening stop. If you've never used the **Port Logbook** all week, this is the night to start — Victoria is the week's punctuation, worth saving a sentence about.

Day 8 — Saturday, July 18 — Seattle (debarkation)

The realistic timeline:

- **6:00 – 8:00 AM:** Breakfast at Garden Café or Manhattan Room.
- **6:30 AM:** Bags must be in the hall the night before (NCL color-codes by tag).
- **7:00 – 9:30 AM:** Walk-off in waves by tag color. **Self-disembarkation** (carry all bags off; first off the ship around 7:00 AM) is the fastest if you have a flight to catch.
- **10:00 AM (latest):** All passengers off the ship.

Tipping at the end of the cruise. NCL's auto-gratuity is added daily (\$20/day per person at most cabin categories; \$25/day in Suites and Haven; verify). Additional cash tips for outstanding service: stateroom steward \$30–50; dining-room waiter \$20–40; group-dinner servers if a consistent person handled the three specialty nights.

Port Valet — use it. The Port of Seattle's free Port Valet service transfers your checked bag from the ship directly to your final-destination airline check-in. Walk off Bliss with only your carry-on; your bag meets you in baggage claim at home. Available for most major airlines on most departure days; sign-up sheet is distributed onboard mid-cruise (typically Day 4 or 5 — watch the *Freestyle Daily*). Free. The piece of Seattle post-cruise logistics that saves the most luggage friction.

Killing time before an evening flight. Pier 66 has a Crew Center bag-storage service: \$6/bag/day, pickup deadline 3 PM. If you'd rather hand the bag off to your airline via Port Valet (above), do that — but Crew Center storage works if Port Valet didn't fit your routing.

Pier 66 is downtown — most of central Seattle is walkable from the terminal. With four to six hours free:

- **Pike Place Market** is a 10-minute walk from Pier 66 (uphill on the way back). Quietest before 9 AM, busy from 10. Coffee at the original Starbucks line is a tourist tax; the Crumpet Shop and Beecher's are better food.
- **Olympic Sculpture Park** is a 5-minute walk north from Pier 66 along the waterfront — free, 30-minute outdoor loop overlooking Elliott Bay.
- **Seattle Aquarium** is 5 minutes south along the waterfront (\$40, ~90 min).
- **Seattle Art Museum** is 10 min on foot from Pier 66, downtown (\$30, the Hammering Man sculpture is the landmark; the special exhibits are usually worth the ticket).
- **Space Needle / Chihuly Garden** is a 15-min walk or a 5-min Uber to Seattle Center (\$35 each; a 90-min combined visit).
- **Pioneer Square** is a 15-min walk south — historic district, used-bookstores, the Underground Tour if a Bliss-adjacent group activity appeals.

SEA without an Uber — Pier 66 is the pack where this actually works. From Pier 66, walk 8 minutes to Westlake Station (or take the free downtown circulator) and catch the **Link light rail** directly to SEA: **\$3.00 flat fare, ~40 minutes, no transfer.** This is the cheapest, most reliable airport route from any Seattle cruise pier. Cost-vs-Uber math: Link saves \$50–70. With bags, it's manageable on Link's roomy trains; the airport-direction trains run every 8 min. Alternative: Quick Shuttle / Capital Aeroporter shared shuttle from Pier 66, \$20–30/person, slower than Link.

Door-to-door Uber/Lyft from Pier 66 to SEA: \$40–60, 25–35 minutes — usable if you're traveling with more bags than Link comfortably handles or if your group splits the cost.

Airport-arrival timing. For a domestic flight after 5 PM, leave Pier 66 by 2 PM if on Link, by 2:30 PM if in an Uber. For an international flight after 7 PM, leave by 3 PM. SEA TSA lines run 30–60 min during Saturday afternoon cruise debark.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

A staged checklist tied to typical cruise booking and travel windows.

6+ months before — booking and big decisions

- **Confirm group booking with the travel agent: Tina Maulsby at Maulsby Travel Co..** Booking and inclusions (Free at Sea perks, drinks bundle, Wi-Fi minutes) go through Tina. On-board-week questions go to Kristie.
- **Decide on cabin category** — see Section 1. Solo Studio is the value play; other categories typically don't waive the supplement.
- **Travel insurance.** For an Alaska cruise, “trip interruption” and “medical evacuation” coverage matter — Alaska air ambulance flights are expensive.
- **Book pre-cruise hotel in Seattle.** The Sound Hotel Belltown is the convenient choice for the Friday “Get Acquainted” dinner; anywhere walking-distance from Pier 66 works.

3 months before — soft logistics

- **Plan flights to Seattle.** Sea-Tac (SEA) is the only realistic option. Arrive Friday for the group dinner if you want that, otherwise by Saturday morning at the very latest.
- **Submit any NCL Latitudes status match** if you've sailed other lines.
- **Cabin number assignment.** NCL assigns specific cabin numbers closer to sailing for some categories.

2 months before — final commitments

- **Final payment** to NCL (typically 90–120 days before sailing — confirm exact date).
- **Pre-cruise purchases** in the Cruise Planner: drinks package (if not bundled), specialty dining package (the 3-meal SDP covers Kristie's three group nights if you're attending all), spa, excursions, internet.

-
- **Confirm the group's three specialty dining reservations** with Kristie — she's holding the table; let her know if you're attending each.

1 month before — final prep window

- **Online check-in** opens 21–30 days before sailing in the NCL app.
- **Download the NCL app** and complete check-in.
- **Confirm Friday Currant Bistro attendance** with Kristie if you're arriving Friday.
- **Review your packing list** against the Alaska-specific items in Section 4.

14 days before — soft logistics

- Print or save digitally any documents you want as backup.
- Notify your bank and credit card issuers of travel.
- Charge all devices, cameras, binoculars 2 days before.

Day before — Seattle arrival

- Arrive Friday for the group dinner, or Saturday morning at the very latest.
 - **8:30 PM Friday:** “Get Acquainted” dinner at Currant Bistro, Sound Hotel Belltown.
 - Pre-pack your Day-1 carry-on (see Section 2 — Day 1).
 - Sleep early; the embarkation morning is logistical.
-

Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for Alaska, 7 nights, July)

This list is tuned for: **Alaska summer (July)** — generally 55–70°F daytime, 50–60°F evenings, frequent rain, occasional 75°F afternoons. **Five port days** mostly walking + outdoor activity. **One sea day with significant deck-observation time.** **NCL’s smart-casual evening dress culture** (no formal nights; one optional “Norwegian’s Night Out” is a slightly dressier evening but jacket not required).

If you remember nothing else: **the Alaska packing rule is layering.** A thermal, a fleece, a waterproof shell — you’ll wear all three on the same morning some days.

Documents and money

- Passport (preferred). Victoria BC on Day 7 is a foreign port; passport is the cleaner path. Birth certificate + state ID is technically accepted but a passport eliminates Day-1 check-in friction.
- NCL booking confirmation and check-in QR (printed and saved on phone).
- Kristie’s group contact card / printed schedule (she’s distributing at sailaway).
- Credit card you trust (notify the issuer of travel; international fees waived if available).
- ~\$200 USD cash in \$5/\$10/\$20 bills for tips, excursion guides, taxis, small purchases. **No CAD needed** for Victoria — USD is accepted.

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications + 3-day buffer (NEVER in checked bags).
- Daily / scheduled / controlled-substance prescriptions in original labeled bottles.
- Swimsuit (the heated Aqua Park pools open before bags arrive).
- Phone, charger, backup battery.
- Reading material for the pre-cabin window.
- Small refillable water bottle.
- Travel documents.

Outerwear (the layering system)

- **Base layer:** thermal long-sleeve top + thermal long underwear (for cold mornings on deck — synthetic or merino, not cotton).
- **Mid layer:** fleece pullover or down sweater. Worn most port days.
- **Outer shell:** waterproof and windproof rain jacket. Not a fashion jacket — a real shell. **The most important single item.**
- Hat (warm beanie, not just a baseball cap).
- Light gloves.
- Scarf or buff for cold mornings on Observation Lounge / Sea View Bar.

For the port days

- **Sturdy walking shoes** — broken in. The Sitka totem trail, Saxman Native Village, Mount Roberts Tramway top trails all involve walking distance.
- **Daypack** (hiking-style, ~15–20L).
- **Binoculars** (8x42 or 10x42) for whale-watching and wildlife.
- **Sun hat / cap** (rare clear day at altitude burns fast).
- **Sunglasses** (polarized for water glare).
- **Sunscreen** (SPF 30+; reef-safe if going on whale-watching tours).

For the ship — daytime

- 7 daily outfits — comfortable casual; jeans or cargo pants are fine.
- 5–6 t-shirts or long-sleeve casual tops.
- Lightweight long-sleeve shirts for sun protection.
- Comfortable walking shoes (in addition to your port-day pair).
- Sandals or flip-flops for the Aqua Park.

For the ship — evening

- 5–6 evening outfits — NCL's dress code is **smart casual** all week.
- 1 nicer outfit for the group specialty-dining nights (Cagney's, Le Bistro especially). Dressy jeans + a button-down, a casual dress, dressy linen.

-
- Light layer (sweater) for cold AC inside venues.
 - **No formal nights on NCL** — leave the tuxedo at home.

Solo / quiet items

- A book or e-reader for the Observation Lounge.
- A small lock for valuables (the cabin safe is sufficient; this is for the daypack at ports).

(No pen needed — US re-entry customs is handled automatically behind the scenes on this closed-loop sailing, and free pens are all over the ship.)

Optional but useful

- **Magnetic hooks** (4–6) — Bliss's cabin walls are steel; stick hooks for jackets, hats, wet swimsuits. See **cabin organization**.
- **A travel mug** for Observation Lounge coffee.
- **Reusable rubber duck** — the **cruise duck tradition**; hide one on the ship for someone else to find.
- **A small folding stool or stadium cushion** for extended deck observation in the Inside Passage.

Skip

- Hairdryer (cabin has one).
 - Iron (not allowed).
 - Heavy formal wear (no formal nights).
 - Beach umbrellas (Alaska beaches don't need them).
 - Power strips with surge protection (banned by most cruise lines for safety; bring a USB-equipped charging cube).
 - Currency exchange (USD is fine for Victoria).
-

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The real “what does this trip cost” math for a 7-night NCL Bliss Alaska group cruise. Numbers approximate; verify in the NCL app and with Kristie.

On cabin category: the budget math below uses the **Solo Studio Cabin rate of \$1,269** advertised on the flyer (no single supplement; Free at Sea–eligible). Oceanview, Balcony, Mini-Suite, and Haven categories are bookable through the group at different rates — most do not waive the solo supplement, so the per-person fare jumps meaningfully. **Confirm category-specific group pricing with Tina Maulsby at Maulsby Travel Co..** Tina holds the master pricing; Kristie handles the on-board experience.

What’s included in your fare

- All meals at Manhattan Room, Taste, Savor, Garden Café, The Local, Observation Lounge coffee bar.
- Non-alcoholic drinks at meals.
- All on-board entertainment (theater shows, comedy, live music, trivia).
- All gym access.
- All on-board activities: Aqua Park (including Ocean Loops), Observation Lounge, Sea View Bar, pools.
- **Studio Lounge access** (Studio cabin guests).

What’s NOT included

Item	Approximate per-person cost (7 nights)
Auto-gratuity (NCL service charge)	~\$140 standard / ~\$175 Suites & Haven
Premium Beverage Package (if not Free at Sea-bundled)	~\$760 + 20% gratuity pre-cruise
Specialty Dining Package (3 meals)	~\$120–180 pre-cruise — covers Kristie’s three group specialty nights

Item	Approximate per-person cost (7 nights)
Shore excursions — Juneau	\$79 (Glacier Express) to \$699+ (helicopter + dog sled)
Shore excursions — Icy Strait Point	\$0 (walking + free gondola) to \$199 (ZipRider walk-up)
Shore excursions — Sitka	\$0 (free downtown shuttle; The RIDE \$2–5) to \$225 (sea otter & whale tour)
Shore excursions — Ketchikan	\$0 (walking) to \$500 (Misty Fjords flightseeing)
Shore excursions — Victoria	\$0 (walking) to ~\$105 all-in (Butchart Gardens + transport)
Wi-Fi (NCL Internet)	\$140–280 depending on package
Spa treatments	\$200–400 (one treatment)
Photo package	\$150–350
Casino, bingo, art auctions	wide range
Pre-cruise Seattle hotel (Friday + Saturday)	\$300–600 (two nights)
Sea-Tac transfers	\$60–100 round trip
Friday Currant Bistro dinner	\$40–80 for appetizers and a couple of drinks
Cash for ports + tips	\$250–400

A realistic mid-range Studio-solo budget (per person, 7 nights, on top of cruise fare)

For a Studio cabin solo cruiser doing pay-as-you-go drinks and 3 ship excursions:

- Studio cabin (group rate): \$1,269
- Auto-gratuity: \$140
- Drink-as-you-go (~4 cocktails + coffee/day): \$280
- Specialty Dining Package (3 meals — Kristie's three group nights): \$130
- Juneau (Glacier Express \$79 + Mount Roberts tram \$65): \$144
- Sitka (packaged Fortress of the Bear + Raptor Center tour): \$80

-
- Ketchikan (shuttle + Totem Heritage Center \$7 + Lumberjack Show \$37): \$44
 - Icy Strait Point (walking + Tribal Dance performance): \$25
 - Victoria (walking + cab to/from): \$20
 - Wi-Fi (basic): \$140
 - Pre-cruise hotel + transfers (Friday + Saturday): \$450
 - Friday Currant Bistro dinner: \$60
 - Cash for ports + tips: \$250

Total beyond cruise fare: ~\$1,760. Trip total: ~\$3,030 per person.

If your shape is different, drop your numbers into the **cruise-budget-calculator**.

How to spend less

- Skip the Drinks Package if not bundled — most short-cruise drinkers don't break even.
- Independent excursions (the \$79 Glacier Express vs. the \$80–120 ship-sold Mendenhall saves up to \$40; local taxi to Saxman saves \$20+).
- Skip Wi-Fi or buy minimal package — port days have cell service.
- Walking-only Victoria.
- Skip the photo package.

How it costs more

- Balcony or Mini-Suite cabin (single supplement applies; meaningful jump in price).
- The Haven enclave (more comfort, more expense; opt-out of Studio culture).
- Helicopter glacier landing in Juneau or Skagway-equivalent option.
- Misty Fjords flightseeing in Ketchikan.
- ZipRider at Icy Strait Point (\$199 walk-up; cruise-line bookings vary) and the Chichagof brown-bear search (~\$163).
- Multiple non-group specialty dinners.

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** covers cash-tip math beyond auto-gratuity. For broader context on cruise tipping practices, see **Cruise Tipping in 2026**.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section. If you're the cruiser preparing for the trip, fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore.

The family handoff card

Copy this, fill in your specifics, and share:

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: _____
CABIN: _____
SHIP: Norwegian Bliss
LINE: Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
SAILING: July 11 – 18, 2026
FROM: Pier 66, Bell Street Cruise Terminal,
Seattle, WA, USA
ITINERARY: Seattle → Sitka → Juneau (+ Dawes
Glacier) → Icy Strait Point →
Ketchikan → Victoria BC → Seattle
GROUP HOST: Kristie McClung Escoe
(group contact info: ask Kristie)

EMERGENCY (24/7) – US State Dept, Overseas
Citizens Services (can locate the ship and
contact NCL through official channels):
+1 (888) 407-4747 (US/Canada)
+1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)

SHIP-TO-SHORE (non-emergency messages only):
NCL paid ship-phone relay: +1 (888) 627-4477
(credit card required; per-minute rate)

NEAREST EMBASSY/CONSULATE BY PORT:
Seattle, WA – US domestic; call 911
Juneau, AK – US domestic; call 911 or
US Coast Guard Juneau: +1 (907) 463-2980
Icy Strait Pt – US domestic; call 911
Sitka, AK – US domestic; call 911
Ketchikan, AK – US domestic; call 911
Victoria, BC – US Consulate Vancouver: +1 (604) 685-4311
Canada emergency: 911

CRUISER MEDICAL:
Allergies: _____
Medications: _____
Conditions: _____
Insurance: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:
Track at: /tools/ship-tracker.html
or marinetracker.com (search "Norwegian Bliss")

What an at-home contact actually does

If they don't hear from you for 36+ hours and they're worried:

1. **Don't panic.** Cruise Wi-Fi is unreliable and silence usually means signal, not emergency.
2. **For a true emergency, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** (above) — they can locate the ship and contact NCL through official channels at no cost. For a non-urgent message, NCL's paid ship-phone relay (above) connects to the ship's onboard phone system.
3. **Reach Kristie** if you've shared her contact info — she's your in-person on the ship and likely has eyes on the group sooner than family ashore can.
4. **If NCL confirms you're not aboard or there's been an incident:** US Coast Guard for Alaska waters; US Consulate Vancouver for Victoria; NCL's on-board medical team for medical issues.
5. **Track the ship's position** using the link above for context.

What you should pack for emergencies

- Printed list of medications, allergies, and emergency contacts (in your cabin nightstand)
 - Photocopy of passport (separate from the passport itself)
 - Travel insurance policy number (printed)
 - The handoff card above, in your phone's notes app and shared with one trusted person
-

Section 7 — Seasickness on an Alaska Cruise

Alaska is calmer than people fear — but this specific route has more open ocean than the phrase “Inside Passage” suggests, and it's worth knowing where. **Sitka faces the open Pacific**, so the Seattle-to-Sitka leg (Day 1 evening through Day 2 and overnight into Monday) runs up the ocean side of Vancouver Island — that's the most exposed

stretch of the week. The middle of the itinerary (Sitka → Juneau → Endicott Arm → Icy Strait Point → Ketchikan) threads properly protected inside waters. Then the **Ketchikan-to-Victoria leg** (Day 6 afternoon through Day 7 evening) returns to the open Pacific before entering the **Strait of Juan de Fuca** for the Victoria approach.

The calibration: if you've been seasick on a Caribbean cruise, you'll most likely still be fine here — July Pacific swell off this coast is usually long-period and gentle, and the ship is large enough (168,028 GT) that moderate water is filtered substantially. If you've never been seasick anywhere, you almost certainly won't start on this itinerary. But the two ocean legs are real ocean; pack the meclizine rather than betting the week on "Inside Passage" branding.

What to bring

- **Bonine** (meclizine) or **Dramamine Less Drowsy** — over-the-counter, take 1 hour before expected motion.
- **Sea-Bands** — pressure-point wristbands.
- **Ginger candies or chews** — backup for mild queasiness.

What helps once you feel it

- **Get on deck.** The Observation Lounge has horizon access in any weather.
- **Eat something dry.** Crackers, dry toast, pretzels.
- **Avoid alcohol** (alcohol exacerbates motion sickness).
- **Take meclizine** at the first hint, not after it's full-on.

If you're motion-sensitive and booked a Studio cabin (interior, no window), spend daylight hours on the Observation Lounge or Sea View Bar — horizon access fixes the problem.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

The NCL app

Download it now (App Store / Google Play). Once your booking is final and you've checked in:

- **Daily program** — schedule of activities, dining hours, show times.
- **Cruise Planner** — pre-cruise booking of drinks, specialty dining, spa, excursions.
- **On-board messaging** — chat with members of your party (Kristie's group, if she sets up a channel) without internet.

The app is functional, not great. Some features only work on the ship's Wi-Fi (not cellular). Plan accordingly.

Onboard internet

NCL's **Internet** is tiered:

- **Wi-Fi Plus** — basic; web, email, social media.
- **Wi-Fi Premium** — streaming; multiple devices; faster.

Pre-cruise pricing is generally cheaper than onboard purchase. For a 7-night cruise, buy only if you actually need it — port days have cell service, sea days are short. The **internet-at-sea** page covers this in more depth.

Cell service

- **In US ports (Seattle, Juneau, Icy Strait Point, Sitka, Ketchikan):** your US carrier works.
- **In Canada (Victoria):** roaming applies. T-Mobile's free roaming covers Canada at slower speeds; AT&T and Verizon charge \$10/day.
- **At sea:** no normal cell service. Default to airplane mode.

Tipping

- **On the ship:** NCL's service charge added daily (\$20/person standard, \$25 in Haven). Covers stateroom, dining, bar. Additional cash tips for outstanding service: steward \$30–50; specialty dining server who handled the group's three nights: \$20–40.
- **In ports:** cash, USD, \$5/\$10 bills. 10–15% on tour cost; \$1–2 per taxi; \$1 per drink.

For broader cruise tipping context, see **Cruise Tipping in 2026**.

Money

- NCL uses your keycard for onboard charges; settle at debarkation via credit card.
- Bring USD cash for ports and tips (~\$200 in small bills).
- ATMs exist in all five Alaska ports + Victoria; bring cash from home if practical.

Accessibility on Bliss and in port

Norwegian Bliss was built with current accessibility standards in 2018; the ship is well-equipped for mobility-limited travelers, low-vision/low-hearing accommodations, and service-animal needs. Key notes:

On the ship:

- **Accessible cabins** are available across categories (Studio, Interior, Oceanview, Balcony, Mini-Suite, Haven). Book early; Alaska sailings draw accessibility-focused groups and these cabins run out first.
- **Elevators** are abundant; most decks are reachable without stairs.
- **Manhattan Room, Taste, Savor, Garden Café** — all fully accessible.
- **Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — fully accessible; the largest indoor seating area on the ship, with plenty of room for chairs and mobility devices.
- **Aqua Park (Ocean Loops, Aqua Racer, Free Fall)** — slides have specific physical-requirement limits (height, weight, mobility); check at the venue.
- **Studio Lounge** — fully accessible.
- **The Haven enclave** — fully accessible across its 8 decks.

-
- **Service animals** — accommodations available; confirm in advance with NCL's accessibility team via the Cruise Planner.

Per-port accessibility:

- **Pier 66 / Seattle** (embark + disembark): fully accessible terminal; 25 handicap parking stalls in the Bell Street Pier garage; level boarding ramps; assistance available at check-in.
- **Sitka (Day 3):** Bliss docks at the Sitka Sound Cruise Terminal — no tender. The free terminal-to-downtown shuttle runs ADA-accessible vehicles. Downtown is mostly flat and paved; the Sitka National Historical Park totem trail is paved and accessibility-graded. The RIDE transit bus is wheelchair-accessible (verify with the operator).
- **Juneau (Day 4 morning):** dock port; some uphill walks downtown, but the **M&M Tours Glacier Express** Mendenhall tour is wheelchair-accessible (confirm in advance). Mount Roberts Tramway car is accessible. Whale-watching boats vary by operator; verify accessibility at booking.
- **Endicott Arm / Dawes Glacier (Day 4 afternoon):** scenic cruising only; all viewing from on-ship venues. Observation Lounge, Sea View Bar, your balcony — all accessible.
- **Icy Strait Point (Day 5):** Bliss docks — no tender. The free Transporter Gondola between Wilderness Landing and the cannery area is enclosed and step-free. The cannery-museum area is paved and flat; the 1.6-mile Hoonah village walk is along a flat road. ZipRider has specific physical requirements (height, weight, mobility — verify at booking).
- **Ketchikan / Ward Cove (Day 6):** dock at Ward Cove; the NCL shuttle to downtown is accessible. Downtown Creek Street has lipped boardwalk transitions (wooden plank boardwalk). Saxman Native Village and Totem Bight are mostly flat but unpaved in places.
- **Victoria, BC (Day 7 evening):** dock at Ogden Point; the shuttle to Inner Harbour is accessible. Inner Harbour is fully accessible (paved, level). Butchart Gardens has some grade changes but is mostly accessible (verify with the gardens in advance).

The **In the Wake disability-at-sea** page covers cross-line accessibility considerations in more depth.

Safety in the Alaska ports

Alaska's cruise-port towns are among the safest stops in any cruise itinerary. Crime rates are low; "tourism crime" is mostly opportunistic theft, easily avoided. The bigger risks are weather (slip-and-fall on wet boardwalks; getting cold and wet) and wildlife (don't approach bears; if a bear is on a Ketchikan trail, walk slowly the other way; never run). The **disability-at-sea** page covers accessible-transit considerations.

Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm (Kristie's plan)



Kristie McClung Escoe — your on-board group host on this sailing

This is the section to read first if you're already on the ship or arriving Friday in Seattle.

Who's running what — host vs agent

- **Kristie McClung Escoe is your on-board host.** She runs the in-person rhythm — the Friday dinner, the sailaway, the daily presence, the group dining nights. She's the person you talk to about *who's doing what when* during the trip.
- **Tina Maulsby at Maulsby Travel Co. is the travel agent.** Tina booked the group rate and is the source of truth for what's bundled with your fare (Free at Sea perks, included drinks, included Wi-Fi, etc.). Booking-and-inclusion questions go to Tina; on-board-week questions go to Kristie.

Get to know your host

Kristie put this card together as a host introduction — in her own words, in her own design. The shape of a hosted group takes after the person running it; if you're wondering whether her group is your group, the card reads like she sounds.



Kristie's host-introduction card — hobbies, about-me, cruise things she loves, family + work background

A few things from the card worth keeping in mind for the week:

- **She's been to Alaska three times already** — 2007, 2018, and one more in between. When she points at something on deck and says *watch this*, she's seen it.
- **Day job: public school staff. Side business: sports photography.** Summer is her travel window; she travels because the schools are out. If trip photos matter to you, she's the one to ask about a camera setup.

- **Cruise things she loves:** excursions, ship food, karaoke (her stated guilty pleasure), trivia games, the slow rhythm of sea days. If trivia is your thing, find her — she'll be on a team.
- **Travel résumé:** Mexico, Caribbean, Alaska (×3), British Isles. On her list: a European Christmas-market river cruise, and Greece.
- **Small details from the card you'll see show up:** Diet Dr Pepper, chocolate, 80s music, and “smiley faces way more than is probably necessary :)”

The week's anchor moments

Date	Time	Where	What
Fri Jul 10	8:30 PM	Currant Bistro @ Sound Hotel Belltown	“Get Acquainted” — casual hotel bistro; appetizers and drinks for purchase. <i>Confirm with Kristie whether she's holding a table or whether group members are showing up à la carte.</i>
Fri Jul 10	9:30 – 11:00 PM	Currant Bistro (same room)	Happy Hour
Sat Jul 11	4:00 PM	Sea View Bar, Deck 17	Sailaway with Kristie; she's distributing the week's printed info
Sat Jul 11	5:00 PM	(venue per Kristie — confirm the week of)	Group dinner — open to anyone joining
Sat Jul 11	TBD (per NCL)	(per NCL)	NCL's on-board solo-group meet-and-greet — Kristie shares the time once NCL confirms

Date	Time	Where	What
Sun Jul 12	5:00 PM	Teppanyaki	Specialty dinner — group reservation (sea day; easy to make)
Tue Jul 14	5:30 PM	Cagney's Steakhouse	Specialty dinner — group reservation (<i>this dinner sits in the middle of the Dawes Glacier scenic-cruising afternoon; see Day 4 for the tradeoff</i>)
Wed Jul 15	5:45 PM	Le Bistro	Specialty dinner — group reservation (after the Icy Strait Point 3 PM departure; comfortable to make)

What to expect on the standing dinners

- **Arrive 5–10 minutes early.** Specialty venues hold the table; arriving on time keeps the group seated together.
- **Order what you want.** There's no "group menu." Each restaurant serves its full menu.
- **The three specialty venues each fill ~90 minutes.** Plan your day around the slot.
- **Dress for it.** Smart casual works at Teppanyaki and Cagney's; Le Bistro tends slightly dressier (a casual dress, dressy jeans + button-down, dressy linen separates).

What Kristie does NOT pre-plan

- **Daily excursions, port days, evening shows, late-night.** You build those.

-
- Kristie has set up a **shared planning Google Sheet** that currently serves as the group's introduction roster (each member's name, location, cruise history, hobbies, anything they want to share). Future tabs will add excursion sign-ups:
 - **Shared planning sheet**
 - As of the most recent read, the group included ~8 members from across the US plus Australia — a mix of first-time Alaska cruisers and experienced cruisers, many widowed or solo by life-stage. Several members are flying into Seattle Saturday morning between 9 and 10 AM.
 - This is opt-in coordination — list your plans if you want company, see what others are doing, and reach out directly if anyone's plan matches yours.

How the group actually works — the unwritten part

The schedule above is the written part. The unwritten part is what most first-time group cruisers actually wonder about, so here it is plainly:

- **Every event is opt-in, and opting out costs you nothing.** Skip Teppanyaki because you'd rather watch the Inside Passage from the Observation Lounge? Nobody logs it. The anchor moments exist so the group can find each other at predictable times — not so attendance can be taken. You haven't missed the group; you'll see them at the next anchor.
- **"No thanks, I'm doing my own thing today" is a complete sentence.** On a solo group cruise specifically, everyone aboard has needed alone-time at some point — they recognize it in others and don't take it personally. Neither will Kristie.
- **Dinner-table norms:** at the three group specialty nights, sit anywhere; there's no fixed seating and no group menu. The other four nights, the group has no claim on your evening — dine solo with a book, join Studio Lounge neighbors, or knock on the shared sheet for company. All three are normal.
- **A friendly port-day is not a commitment to every port-day.** Sharing a taxi to Mendenhall on Tuesday doesn't obligate you to anyone's Ketchikan plan on Thursday. Pairings form and re-form all week; that's the design, not a failure of the design.
- **A group this size produces a few real connections, not a crowd of them.** Eight to a dozen people across a week tends to yield two or three friendships that outlast

the trip and a circle of friendly faces. That's a good outcome — don't measure the week against "everyone became best friends."

Questions worth asking Kristie before you sail

She's been to Alaska three times; the pack can describe the ports, but she's stood on these decks. Worth asking her directly — at the Friday dinner, on the shared sheet, or at sailaway:

- How does she plan to handle the **Tuesday Cagney's-vs-Dawes-Glacier collision** herself? (Her answer is the closest thing to a verdict this pack can't give you.)
- What does she **skip** in these ports that first-timers usually waste money on?
- Where was she standing the last time a glacier calved in front of her — and where will she be standing this time?
- What's the one thing she packs for Alaska that nobody else thinks to bring?

If you want company beyond the group

- **The Studio Lounge** (if you're in a Studio cabin) — built-in solo community, hosted hours.
- **The Observation Lounge** — the day's social anchor for Alaska cruisers; coffee in hand, scenery passing.
- **Sea View Bar** (Deck 17, where you met for sailaway) — pre-dinner gatherings often form here.
- **Trivia and games** — published in the daily program.

If you want quiet

- **The Observation Lounge** at sunrise — almost no one is up.
- **The Mandara Spa thermal area** — heated stone loungers, sauna, steam; quiet by design.
- **Your cabin balcony** (if you booked one).
- **Studio cabin and Studio Lounge off-hours.**

The group is the floor, not the ceiling. Build the cruise you want on top of it.

Section 10 — Solo Cruising Considerations

A hosted solo group cruise on NCL Bliss is one of the strongest solo formats in the industry. Studio cabins with no single supplement, the Studio Lounge as a daily social anchor, the Observation Lounge as Alaska's natural gathering point, and Kristie's set rhythm above all combine into a low-friction solo experience.

Practical solo notes:

- **The Studio supplement is zero.** Studio cabins are priced for one. This is rare in the cruise industry and material to budget math.
- **The Studio Lounge** runs hosted coffee hours mornings and social hours late afternoon — an anchor independent of Kristie's group meetups.
- **The Observation Lounge** is the all-day solo space in Alaska — bring a book, share a couch, no obligation to talk.
- **Pool deck mid-afternoon** is the most social part of the day if you want to meet people who aren't in the group.
- **Sea View Bar** (where sailaway happens) is the pre-dinner gathering spot.
- **Don't feel obligated to do dinner only with the group.** Kristie's three specialty nights are anchors; the other four nights, you can dine solo at any included venue, find Studio neighbors, or join Studio Lounge spontaneous groups.

The broader site's **solo articles hub** carries Tina Maulsby's thinking on solo cruising — worth reading in any order:

- **Why I Started Solo Cruising** — the origin story.
- **The Freedom of Your Own Wake** — what solo specifically gives you that grouped travel doesn't.
- **Solo Cruising — a Practical Guide** — the operational depth: cabins, tipping, dining, embarkation as a solo.
- **In the Wake of Grief** — for travelers cruising after loss; tactful, real. (*Kristie's group includes several members in this season of life.*)
- **Solo Cruisers' Companion** — the broader companion piece.

Solo safety — cabin and onboard

Solo cruising is overwhelmingly safe — cruise ships are among the most surveilled travel environments anywhere, with CCTV in common areas, 24-hour security, controlled deck access, and crew trained in emergency response. The Cruise Vessel Security and Safety Act (federal U.S. law since 2010) mandates specific protocols including camera coverage and reporting obligations. None of that makes risk zero, but the baseline is high. A few habits still make sense:

Your cabin door. The standard NCL cabin door has both a deadbolt and a privacy latch (a small swing-arm that keeps the door from opening even with a master key). Use both at night. Some solo cruisers add a portable door wedge — under \$10, takes no space, and for travelers who sleep uneasily in unfamiliar rooms it's calming beyond any actual security gain.

Share your itinerary before sailing. Send the day-by-day to one trusted person ashore, with your cabin number once assigned and your travel insurance policy number. The family handoff card in **Section 6** is built for exactly this — including the State Department's 24/7 line, which can locate the ship and reach NCL through official channels at no cost to your family.

Friendliness is not obligation. A good conversation at trivia is not an invitation to dinner; a shared dinner is not an invitation to a port day; a port day is not an invitation to anything else. You set the pace, and on a hosted solo cruise specifically, declining doesn't fracture anything — see the group-dynamics notes in **Section 9**.

If something feels off, Guest Services and the 24-hour security desk respond fast — for an intrusive fellow passenger, an overstepping crew member, anything. Most solo cruisers go a lifetime without needing this; the option exists if you do.

A small joy: cruise ducks

There's a tradition on cruise ships of bringing small rubber ducks and hiding them around the ship for fellow passengers to find. Solo cruisers often find this cheerfully ridiculous — which is the point. If you want to participate, see **the cruise duck tradition article**.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise of any kind (not just first NCL or first Alaska), a few things that won't be obvious:

The ship is a small city. 4,000+ passengers, 1,700 crew, 20 decks. You won't see all of it. Make peace with this.

Embarkation is logistical, not magical. Day 1 is paperwork, lines, and finding things. The good part starts on Day 2.

The buffet (Garden Café) is not the best food on the ship. It's fine. The Manhattan Room dinner is the better meal. Eat there at least 2 of the 4 nights you're not doing group specialty dining.

You're going to forget your keycard the first day. Everyone does. Get a lanyard.

The first sea day, you'll feel disoriented. Normal. Pick 2 things from the daily program, do them, sit down, stare at water. You'll find the rhythm.

The crew remembers you. Your stateroom steward, the bartender at Sea View Bar — they learn your name, your drink preferences, your allergies. The relationship is real. It's worth being kind, and worth tipping in cash above the auto-gratuity if service warrants it.

NCL is more casual than the other major US lines. No formal nights. The Freestyle Dining model means you set your own schedule.

The Observation Lounge is where you'll spend your best Alaska hours. Make peace with this too. Coffee, a book, the Inside Passage moving past.

You'll spend more on excursions than you think. Build a shore-day budget before sailing. The **cruise-budget-calculator** helps prevent the surprise.

You'll come home wanting to go back. Most first-time Alaska cruisers do another within 2 years. Plan accordingly.

For more first-cruise context across cruise lines, see the broader **first-cruise guide**.

Continue planning on the site

A few threads worth pulling on the rest of the site as your sailing date approaches.

About your ship

- **Video walkthroughs of Norwegian Bliss** — short clips of public spaces, Observation Lounge, Aqua Park, deck areas, gathered on her **video highlights section**.
- **Logbook entries from other travelers** — first-hand notes from guests aboard Bliss, on the **Bliss logbook section**.
- **Deck plans and the first-look gallery: first look and deck plans**.

About the ports

Each port has its own page on the site:

- **Seattle port page**
- **Juneau port page**
- **Icy Strait Point port page**
- **Sitka port page**
- **Ketchikan port page**
- **Victoria BC port page**

Other Voyage Packs

The **full Voyage Packs catalog** lists every itinerary **In the Wake** has packed — useful if a future trip is on your mind alongside this one.

Closing

A hosted solo cruise on a Breakaway Plus ship in Alaska in July is a particular kind of week: long daylight, the Inside Passage drifting past your coffee, the company of fellow solos when you want it, and the quiet of your Studio cabin or the Observation Lounge when you don't. Kristie's six anchor moments give the week shape; everything else, you build.

A few things worth remembering as your sailing date approaches:

- **Show up at Sea View Bar at 4 PM Saturday for sailaway.** That's where the group becomes the group, and where Kristie hands you the week's printed info.
- **Three specialty dinners are pre-booked** — Sun Teppanyaki, Tue Cagney's, Wed Le Bistro. A Specialty Dining Package (3 meals) prepaid in the Cruise Planner covers them and costs less than paying individually.
- **The Studio Lounge** is your daily social anchor outside the group meetups. Hosted hours, free coffee, fellow solos.
- **The Observation Lounge** is where Alaska happens. Coffee at sunrise on a sea day is the trip's quietest joy.
- **Layers matter more than the right brand.** A \$30 fleece, a \$50 rain shell, a \$20 thermal — you'll wear them all.
- **The crew makes the trip.** Tip in cash, in envelopes, at the end.

If you want a one-line preflight reminder: **the goal is calm.** Pack early. Sleep before you fly. Get to Pier 66 with margin Saturday morning, drop the bags, walk Pike Place, and come back for sailaway with Kristie at Sea View at 4.

Soli Deo Gloria.

Pack version	v0.1.7 (ncl-bliss-alaska-solo-group-jul-2026)
Sailing	Norwegian Bliss, 7-night Alaska from Seattle, July 11 – 18, 2026
Audience	Solo travelers — Kristie McClung Escoe's hosted group

Group host	Kristie McClung Escoe (group contact info: ask Kristie)
Last reviewed	2026-06-11
How facts here are checked	Every price, time, distance, and docking claim in this pack is checked against a primary source — the port terminals’ own websites (the Sitka terminal’s shuttle system, Icy Strait Point’s berths), the excursion operators’ own price pages (M&M Tours, Goldbelt Tram, Harv & Marv’s, TEMSCO, Butchart Gardens), the National Park Service, NCL’s published materials, and transit timetables. Sources for each claim are kept in this pack’s research log. If a number can’t be sourced, it isn’t asserted here. What’s quoted from Kristie is hers, from her own card and communications.
Accessibility	This pack and the site that produced it follow WCAG 2.1 AA. The Emergency Contacts section is offline-capable via PWA so a trusted contact ashore can keep the family handoff card available without an internet connection.

Sources	Ship: Norwegian Bliss. Ports: Seattle, Sitka, Juneau, Endicott Arm, Icy Strait Point, Ketchikan, Victoria BC. Onboard dining: Manhattan Room, Taste, Savor, Garden Café, The Local, Cagney's Steakhouse, Le Bistro, Teppanyaki, Q Texas Smokehouse, Los Lobos, Food Republic, Ocean Blue, La Cucina, The Haven Restaurant. Bars: Atrium Bar, Maltings Whiskey Bar, Sugarcane Mojito Bar, Bliss Ultra Lounge, Spice H2O, Waves Pool Bar, Studio Lounge, Observation Lounge, Haven Lounge. Host + agent: Kristie McClung Escoe (on-board host), Tina Maulsby + Maulsby Travel Co. (travel agent). Group resources: Sound Hotel Belltown, Currant Bistro, Bell Street Cruise Terminal Pier 66, shared planning Google Sheet. External operators: M&M Tours / Glacier Express, Harv & Marv's whale watching, TEMSCO Helicopters, Butchart Gardens, Royal BC Museum. Tools: cruise-budget-calculator, cruise-tipping-calculator, port-day-planner, port-tracker, ship-tracker, ship-size-atlas, drink-calculator. Reference pages: first-cruise, countdown, packing-lists, internet-at-sea, disability-at-sea. Solo articles: solo hub, Why I Started Solo Cruising, Freedom of Your Own Wake, Solo Cruising Practical Guide, In the Wake of Grief, Solo Cruisers' Companion. Articles: cruise-cabin-organization, cruise-tech-photography-guide, cruise-duck-tradition, cruise-tipping-2026. Catalog: Voyage Packs. Original research: NCL.com, CruiseMapper, gangwaze.com, AlaskaCruises.com, Port of Seattle, Currant Bistro Seattle.
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Pricing reminder	Pricing in this document is approximate. Confirm current rates with Kristie or with NCL directly
Refunds & support	Full refund within 14 days of purchase, no questions — and if a pack has a factual error at any time, email pack-support@cruisinginthewake.com and we'll fix it
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